"I'm a disappointment to my parents."

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Where it often comes from

When grades or milestones are lower than a parent hoped, children can sense disappointment, spoken or not. As adults, they may still hear it, and some parents did say hurtful things.

What Scripture teaches

"Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me." "Before I formed you in the womb I knew you." "Can a woman forget her nursing child…? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you!" God's view of you is not shaped by anyone's expectations. Honor your parents, grieve what hurt, and let your Heavenly Father define you. Many parents also change and learn to see their child's strengths.

> *"Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me"* (Psalm 27:10).

Also see

> "'Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I set you apart and appointed you as a prophet to the nations.'" (Jeremiah 1:5).

> "'Can a woman forget her nursing child, or lack compassion for the son of her womb? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you!'" (Isaiah 49:15).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "'Honor your father and mother' (which is the first commandment with a promise)" (Ephesians 6:2).

Common self-statements

- I let them down.
- They wanted a different child.
- I never met their expectations.
- They are ashamed of me.
- I will never make them proud.
- I am a failure to them.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either a pride or a disappointment.
- Fortune telling: Predicting they will never accept me.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling their disappointment and concluding I am one.
- Mind reading: Calling myself a disappointment.

Challenging questions

- What did my parents actually say, and what did I assume?
- What do I wish they could see?
- What are my parents' own fears or hopes?
- What does God say about me?

- Is it possible to talk with them?
- How can I honor them while defining myself differently?

Truth summary

> My worth is not set by my parents' approval. God received me, knew me, and loves me. I can honor my parents, speak honestly if possible, and let God define me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Parenting
- Self-Esteem, Low
- God, All Loving
- Forgiveness
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I'm a disappointment to my parents"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm a disappointment to my parents." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did my parents actually say, and what did I assume?
- ☐ What do I wish they could see?
- ☐ What are my parents' own fears or hopes?
- ☐ What does God say about me?
- ☐ Is it possible to talk with them?
- ☐ How can I honor them while defining myself differently?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ The Lord receives me.
- ☐ He knew me before I was born.
- ☐ He will not forget me.
- ☐ I am fearfully and wonderfully made.
- ☐ I can honor my parents.
- ☐ I am loved.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 27:10
  "Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me."
- ☐ Jeremiah 1:5
  "'Before I formed you in the womb I knew you, and before you were born I set you apart and appointed you as a prophet to the nations.'"
- ☐ Isaiah 49:15
  "'Can a woman forget her nursing child, or lack compassion for the son of her womb? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you!'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Defined by God: Each week, note one thing God says about you.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 27:10 becomes: "Sarah can write: "The Lord receives me and knew me before I was born.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Write what you heard. Separate fact from assumption.
- [ ] Share with a counselor. Work through the hurt.
- [ ] Consider a conversation. Only if safe and helpful.
- [ ] Read Psalm 27:10. Remember God receives you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm a disappointment to my parents": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Defined by God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm a disappointment to my parents.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have felt like a disappointment. Thank You that You receive me. Heal the hurt, and help me honor my parents while resting in Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.